



THE THIEF'S STORY

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Ruskin Bond

About the Author:

Ruskin Bond is an Indian author of British descent, widely known for his simple, graceful, and deeply human stories. His writing often focuses on children, ordinary people, nature, loneliness, trust, kindness, and moral change. In “**The Thief’s Story**”, he shows how love, trust, and education can reform even a dishonest person without force or punishment.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The power of **trust, kindness, and human goodness** in changing a person.
- **Education** as a path to dignity, self-respect, and a better future.
- The conflict between **dishonesty and conscience**.
- The idea that a person is not permanently bad; the right environment can bring reform.

- Moral transformation through silent understanding instead of harsh punishment.

Values:

- Trust can be stronger than suspicion in reforming someone.
- Kindness must be used wisely; it can awaken guilt and responsibility.
- Education gives a person independence and a respectable identity.
- Self-realisation is more powerful than fear of punishment.
- A second chance can change a person's life if they are ready to learn.

2. Characters

- **Hari Singh:** The young thief and narrator of the story. He is clever, experienced in stealing, and used to changing names to avoid being caught. However, he is not completely heartless; Anil's trust and kindness slowly awaken his conscience.
- **Anil:** A kind, simple, and trusting young man who earns irregularly by writing. He gives Hari Singh shelter, food, work, and education. His calm goodness becomes the main reason behind Hari Singh's moral transformation.
- **The Publisher / People Around Anil:** Minor background figures connected to Anil's work and money. They help show that Anil's income is irregular, but he still remains generous and carefree.

3. Summary

“**The Thief's Story**” is about a young thief named **Hari Singh** who tries to rob a simple and kind man named **Anil**, but finally changes because of Anil's trust. The story is narrated by Hari himself, so we clearly see his thoughts, tricks, guilt, and inner transformation.

Hari Singh is only about fifteen years old, but he is already experienced in stealing. He keeps changing his name every month to avoid the police and old victims. He meets **Anil**, a young man of about twenty-five, at a wrestling

match and quickly decides that Anil will be an easy target because he looks simple, careless, and trusting.

Hari flatters Anil and asks for work. Anil does not have much money, but he allows Hari to stay with him if he can cook. Hari lies that he knows cooking, but the food he prepares is terrible. Anil laughs, forgives him, and decides to teach him how to cook. More importantly, Anil begins teaching him to read, write, and add numbers. This becomes important because education offers Hari a future beyond stealing.

Hari starts living with Anil and doing small household work. He also cheats a little while buying daily supplies, keeping small amounts of money for himself. Anil probably knows this, but he does not expose or punish him. His trust makes Hari feel safe, but it also slowly creates guilt inside him.

One evening, Anil receives a bundle of notes after selling some writing work. Hari sees the money and his old thief-instinct becomes active. At night, when Anil is asleep, Hari quietly takes the money from under the mattress and runs away. He reaches the railway station and has a chance to escape by train.

But at the station, Hari's conscience begins to trouble him. He thinks about Anil's trust, kindness, and the education he was receiving. He realises that if he runs away, he may gain money for a short time, but he will lose the chance to become educated and respected. He understands that Anil's trust is more valuable than the stolen money.

Hari returns in the rain and quietly puts the money back under Anil's mattress. The notes are wet, so it is clear that something happened. In the morning, Anil behaves normally and does not directly accuse Hari. Instead, he gives him a fifty-rupee note and says they will begin writing full sentences that day. Hari understands that Anil knows the truth but has chosen forgiveness instead of punishment.

This silent forgiveness becomes the turning point of the story. Hari feels ashamed, grateful, and changed. Anil's trust gives him a new direction. The story shows that real reform does not always need shouting, beating, or fear.

Sometimes, quiet goodness and faith can make a person choose honesty by himself.

4. Key Points

- **Hari Singh** is a young thief who plans to rob **Anil**.
- **Anil** gives him food, shelter, work, and education despite having little money.
- Hari steals Anil's money but cannot escape because his conscience stops him.
- He returns the money secretly, choosing trust and education over theft.
- Anil understands everything but forgives him silently, helping him reform.

5. Moral

- Trust and kindness can reform a person more deeply than punishment.
- Education is more valuable than stolen money because it gives long-term dignity and independence.
- A person who has done wrong can still change if his conscience is awakened.
- Forgiveness must not be weakness; sometimes it is the strongest way to correct someone.
- Real character is shown when we choose what is right even when escape is possible.

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